ROTTERDAM, NETHERLANDS

Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen: Masterpieces

Mirrors, journeys and imagined landscapes test the rules by which pictures make sense.



Magritte's mirror makes one obvious mistake and one crucially correct reflection. The man's face remains unavailable, but the book behaves normally. A small portion of dependable space makes the larger impossibility harder to dismiss. Other works in this selection unsettle expectations less abruptly: an immense tower dwarfs its builders, a traveller looks back rather than ahead, and a waterfall takes shape from a narrow range of tones.

The common question is how much information a picture needs to persuade. Drawings can leave paper open; a portrait can dispense with a narrative; a landscape can make a tiny settlement sufficient to establish the scale of an entire terrain.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/boijmans-van-beuningen

The selection · 20

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   Hieronymus Bosch · 1500
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19. A River Valley with a Group of Houses
    Hercules Seghers · 1625
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    Gerrit Pietersz Sweelinck · 1605

01 / 20

The Wayfarer

Hieronymus Bosch

1500 · Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen



The wayfarer. WikiArt; Hieronymus Bosch. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The traveller's body carries on while his attention turns back. Bosch makes that divided direction the first problem of the image. The pack and stick identify a journey, but the building, dog and scattered objects complicate its immediate surroundings. Before assigning every detail a fixed moral meaning, follow how the glance interrupts a straightforward movement away.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Saint Christopher

Hieronymus Bosch

1500 · Oil on panel · Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen



Saint Christopher. WikiArt; Hieronymus Bosch. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The staff and leaning body make Christopher's crossing look laborious even before its religious meaning is considered. The child occupies a small area but gives the saint his burden. Bosch surrounds this clear action with a much less easily exhausted landscape. The central task remains intelligible while smaller incidents keep the world from becoming a simple illustration of it.

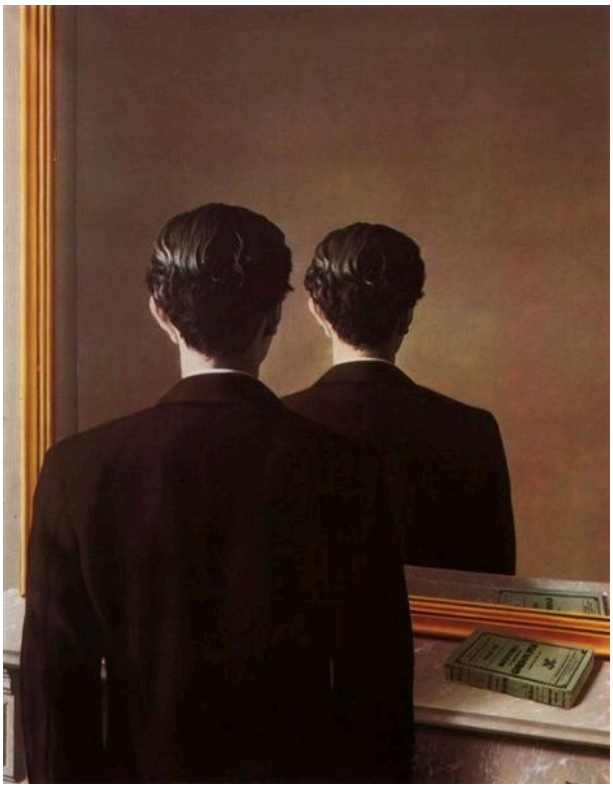
Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Not to Be Reproduced

René Magritte

1937 · Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen



René Magritte. Not to be Reproduced. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

The mirror repeats the back of Edward James's head instead of revealing his face. Its treatment of the book is ordinary, however, so the room does not follow one consistent impossible rule. Magritte supplies a recognisable portrait setting and denies its expected reward. More looking will not bring the face into view; the obstruction is built into the image.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Beach View

Johan Hendrik Weissenbruch

1891 · Oil on canvas · Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen



Johan Hendrik Weissenbruch. Beach view. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/johan-hendrik-weissenbruch/beach-view-1891 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The carts measure a beach with few fixed landmarks. One occupies the nearer wet sand; another recedes towards the water, making the intervening openness easier to judge. Weissenbruch gives considerable space to the pale sky without losing the ground beneath it. A modest moving subject can establish scale more efficiently than a detailed architectural boundary.

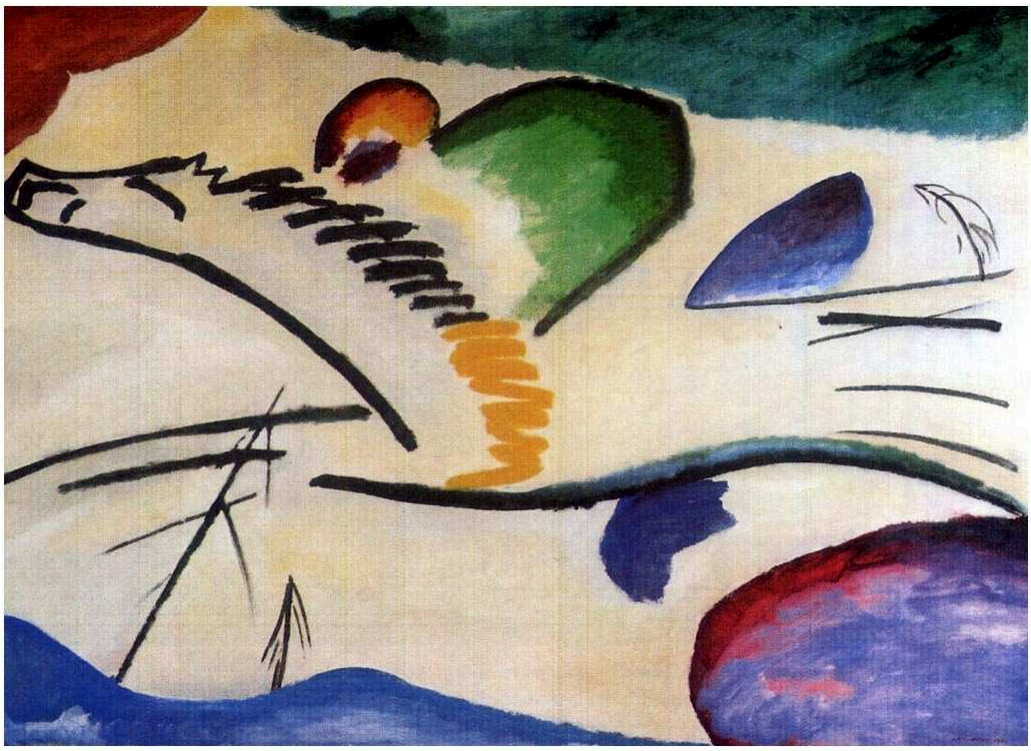
Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Lyrical

Wassily Kandinsky

1911 · Oil on canvas · Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen



Wassily Kandinsky. Lyrical (Lyrics). WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/wassily-kandinsky/lyrical-lyrics-1911 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The suggestion of horse and rider remains available, though much of the setting has fallen away. Long lines carry the action across scattered coloured areas. Kandinsky leaves the subject near the threshold of recognition: the marks can be read as movement through a place or as a movement occurring within the painted surface itself.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Port de Javel

Paul Gauguin

1876 · Oil on canvas · Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen



Port de Javel. WikiArt; Paul Gauguin. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Boats, low buildings and smoke belong to a working riverside, while the extensive clouds make weather an equally substantial part of the view. Gauguin lets industrial activity occupy an intelligible landscape rather than separating it into an emblem of modernity. The scene is useful in its own right, not only as a preliminary to the painter's later work.

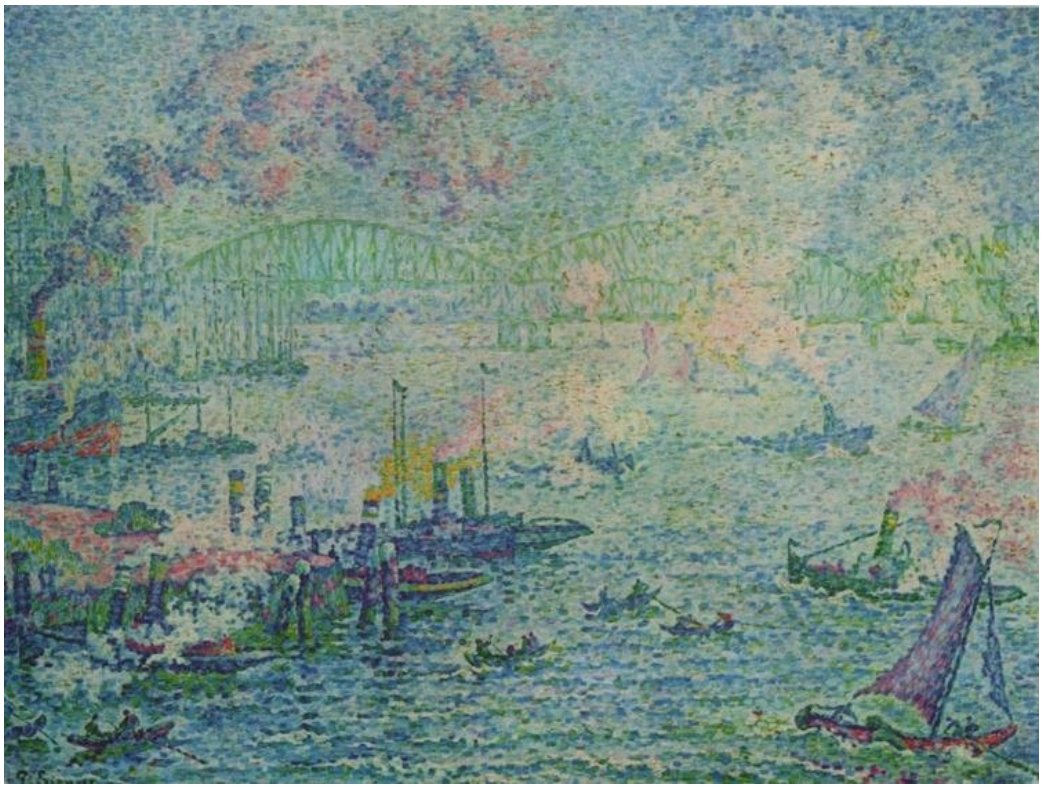
Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

Rotterdam Harbour

Paul Signac

1907 · Oil on canvas · Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen



Rotterdam Harbour. WikiArt; Paul Signac. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The cranes and sails have to be recognised through a surface of small coloured touches. Signac gives machinery and water a shared handling without pretending that they are the same material. Distance softens the far bank, while the active colour remains close to the eye. The harbour's industrial identity survives its transformation into a luminous pattern.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

Two Male Heads

Hieronymus Bosch

c. 1480 · Oil on panel · Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen



Hieronymus Bosch. Two Male Heads. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/hieronymus-bosch/two-male-heads · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The heads stand close enough for differences of glance and expression to become the principal event. Elaborate head coverings add another set of comparisons within the narrow field. With little surrounding narrative to explain them, the faces remain particular but not fully accounted for. Proximity produces a relationship without establishing exactly what the men think of each other.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

The Château of Nègrepelisse

Jean-Honoré Fragonard

1773 · Chalk · Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen



Castle Nègrepeliss. WikiArt; Jean-Honoré Fragonard. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Much of the paper remains available around the warm drawing marks. Fragonard can therefore suggest a substantial building without giving every wall an equally closed boundary. Towers and surrounding terrain emerge through selective description. The economy is instructive: an image can make a site comprehensible while preserving the openness of an initial encounter with it.

Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

The Resurrection of Christ

Pieter Bruegel the Elder

c. 1560 · Chalk on paper · Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen



Pieter Bruegel the Elder. The Resurrection of Christ. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pieter-bruegel-the-elder/the-resurrection-of-christ · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The upright Christ contrasts with the soldiers' disrupted poses around the tomb. Bruegel organises the religious event through different bodily directions, concentrating the drawing below while keeping the rising figure clear. The separation makes the subject readable amid its detail. Stability and disturbance are assigned to different parts of the same scene.

Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

The Little Tower of Babel

Pieter Bruegel the Elder

1563 · Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen



Pieter Bruegel the Elder. The "Little" Tower of Babel. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The tower is graspable as a repeated pattern of arches before its enormous size becomes fully apparent. The small city and river then supply the comparison that makes it overwhelming. Bruegel leaves the upper levels unfinished, so the structure is also an activity still in progress. Its architectural order cannot guarantee that the undertaking will succeed.

Object source · Open artwork

12 / 20

Abraham and the Three Angels

Aert de Gelder

1680–1685 · Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen



Arent de Gelder. Abraham and three Angels. Image credit: Sailko. Wikimedia Commons. CC BY 3.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · CC BY 3.0

The visitors and their host meet around food, giving a divine encounter the arrangement of hospitality. De Gelder lets faces and fabric emerge from a subdued setting rather than announcing the event through an expansive spectacle. The shared table joins the figures, while their separate responses keep the gathering from becoming one undifferentiated expression of reverence.

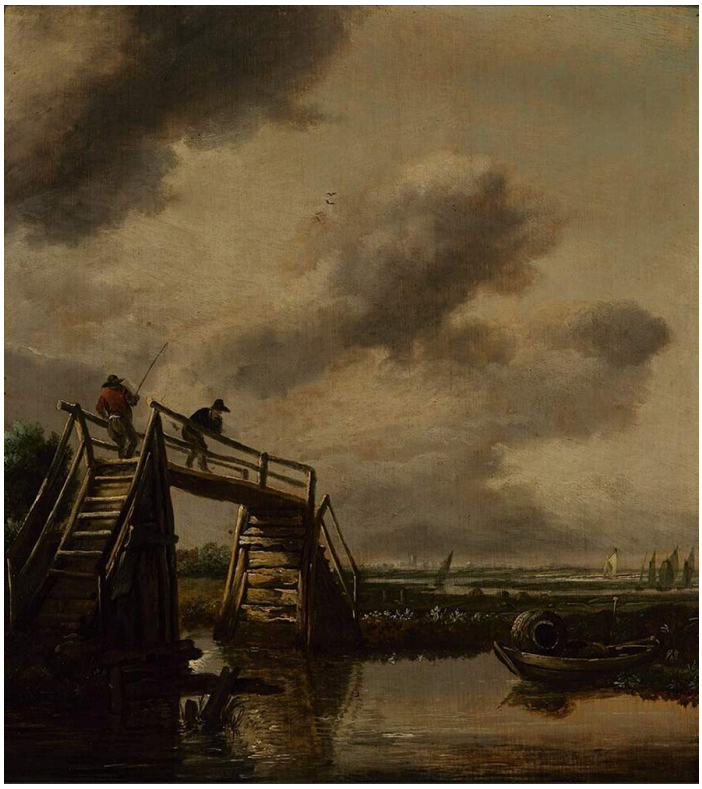
Object source · Open artwork

13 / 20

Anglers on a Small Wooden Bridge

Maerten Fransz. van der Hulst

1640–1645 · Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen



Maerten Fransz. van der Hulst. Anglers on a Small Wooden Bridge. Image credit: Maerten Fransz. van der Hulst. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The bridge provides a firm set of angles against a softer landscape. The anglers lean from that structure, giving its practical purpose a visible human scale. Van der Hulst allows a small pastime to organise a broad view. Water, distant land and sky can remain open because the nearer crossing has already established a place from which to look.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2523 (OK)

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A Small Courtyard

Esaias Boursse

c. 1660 · Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen



Esaias Boursse. Binnenplaatsje. Image credit: Sailko. Wikimedia Commons. CC BY 3.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · CC BY 3.0

Brick walls contain a limited working space, but Boursse differentiates its surfaces rather than treating the enclosure as a single dull background. Cloth, wood and masonry answer the light differently. The bent worker belongs within those practical surroundings. The courtyard acquires specificity from use and material, without needing an exceptional event to justify the picture.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

A Woman Spinning

Gerard ter Borch

1652-1653 · Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen



Gerard ter Borch. A Woman Spinning. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The distance between the hands is small, yet it explains the task. Pale cuffs and collar recover the working figure from the dark room, leaving less relevant surroundings indistinct. Ter Borch makes attention proportionate to the activity: a movement of thread deserves closer description than the larger space that happens to contain it.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

Head of a Cow

Dirck Govertsz

1626–1629 · Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen



Dirck Govertsz. Head of a Cow. Image credit: Dirck Govertsz. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The frontal head adopts a format familiar from human portraiture, but the horns and curling forelock make its proportions unmistakably animal. Unequal light prevents the symmetry from becoming rigid. The close view gives texture and small asymmetries unusual consequence. Individual presence does not depend here on an expressive gesture or a narrative setting.

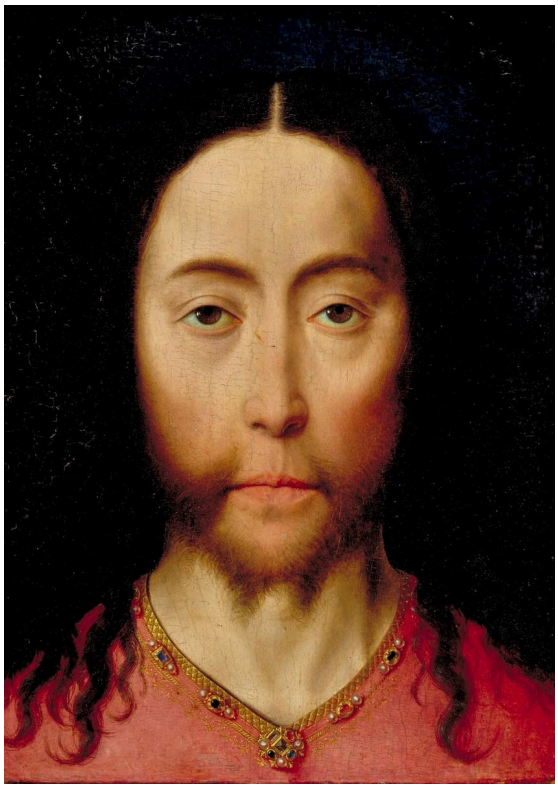
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 3243 (OK)

17 / 20

Head of Christ

Dieric Bouts

c. 1464 · Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen



Dieric Bouts. Head of Christ. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/dirk-bouts/head-of-christ · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

There is no crowd or event to follow. The frontal face and near symmetry concentrate the devotional image into a sustained address, with dark hair and background framing the pale features. Bouts limits the means of distraction. The painting's directness comes from that restriction, quite unlike the crowded religious narratives elsewhere in this selection.

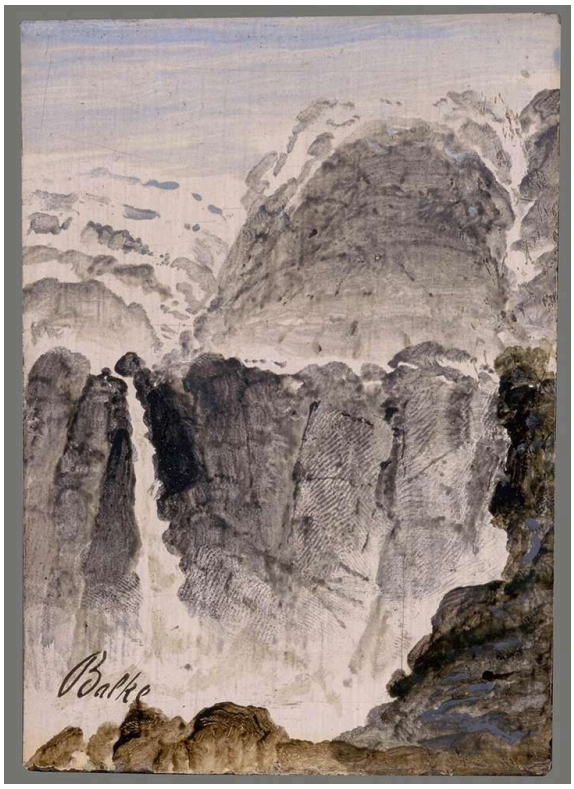
Object source · Open artwork

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Rjukanfossen

Peder Balke

c. 1860 · Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen



Peder Balke. Rjukanfossen. Image credit: Peder Balke; Source credit: Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Dark rock gives the pale falling water its force. Balke needs only a narrow tonal range to distinguish resistant surfaces from mist and dispersed spray. The contrast makes a large landscape readable without exhaustive detail. Notice where a mark ceases to describe a particular stone and begins to carry the general instability of the water beside it.

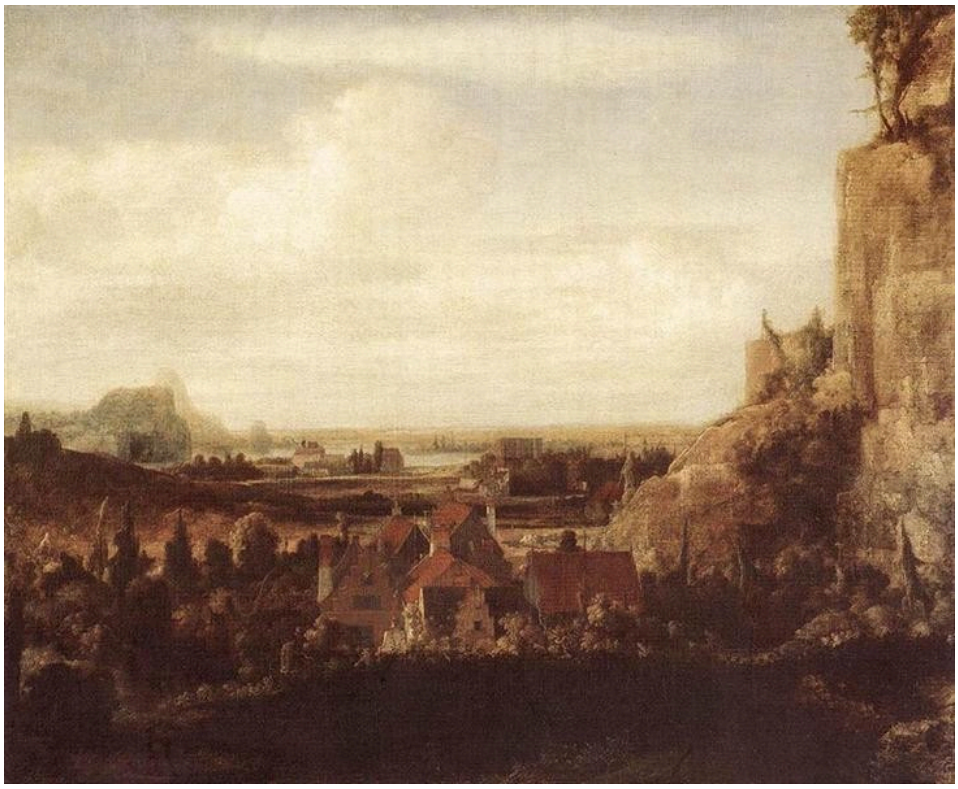
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 3855 (OK)

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A River Valley with a Group of Houses

Hercules Seghers

1625 · Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen



Hercules Seghers. A River Valley with a Group of Houses. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The houses offer a recognisable scale beneath the rocky height. Strong differences between the darker foreground and pale distance make the valley extend beyond that small settlement. Seghers lets habitation provide a foothold within terrain that can otherwise feel difficult to measure. The buildings do not dominate the view; they make its magnitude interpretable.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Judith with the Head of Holofernes

Gerrit Pietersz Sweelinck

1605 · Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen



Gerrit Pietersz Sweelink. Judith with the Head of Holofernes. Image credit: Gerrit Pietersz Sweelink. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The severed head is held low, leaving more space for the women's faces and contrasting ages. Sweelinck gives the aftermath its own subject rather than reconstructing the act of killing. Drapery and shadow concentrate the pair, but their expressions need not be translated into a single assured emotion. The completed deed remains present as a physical object between them.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: St 160

Check the work's location separately

Boijmans's collection records, Depot presentations and loans should not be treated as one permanent hanging. Check the museum's current location and access information for any work you want to see. For reading online, compare Magritte's withheld face with the directness of the *Head of Christ*: each makes visibility itself consequential.

Further reading

Dutch Paintings in The Metropolitan Museum of Art, Volumes I and II

Walter Liedtke · Read online or download · English

Walter Liedtke's Dutch Paintings in The Metropolitan Museum of Art supplies detailed context for the landscapes, portraits and domestic scenes in the middle of this selection. It is particularly useful for comparing the aims of different seventeenth-century genres.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

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